

Primary Source Reading 1: Darwin on the Origin of the Moral Sense

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.07 — Does Evolution Explain Morality? From Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man, Chapter IV (1871)

Before you read: Darwin sets out to explain, in purely naturalistic terms, why a social animal with sufficiently developed intelligence would end up with something recognizable as a conscience. As you read, notice that Darwin is doing biology and psychology here — tracing a causal history — not arguing that the resulting moral feelings are correct. That distinction is exactly what your notebook question asks you to identify.

The Fundamental Proposition

The following proposition seems to me in a high degree probable — namely, that any animal whatever, endowed with well-marked social instincts, the parental and filial affections being here included, would inevitably acquire a moral sense or conscience, as soon as its intellectual powers had become as well, or nearly as well developed, as in man.

Four Reasons the Social Instincts Produce Conscience

For, **FIRSTLY**, the social instincts lead an animal to take pleasure in the society of its fellows, to feel a certain amount of sympathy with them, and to perform various services for them. The services may be of a definite and evidently instinctive nature; or there may be only a wish and readiness, as with most of the higher social animals, to aid their fellows in certain general ways. But these feelings and services are by no means extended to all the individuals of the same species, only to those of the same association.

SECONDLY, as soon as the mental faculties had become highly developed, images of all past actions and motives would be incessantly passing through the brain of each individual: and that feeling of dissatisfaction, or even misery, which invariably results, as we shall hereafter see, from any unsatisfied instinct, would arise, as often as it was perceived that the enduring and always present social instinct had yielded to some other instinct, at the time stronger, but neither enduring in its nature, nor leaving behind it a very vivid impression. It is clear that many instinctive desires, such as that of hunger, are in their nature of short duration; and after being satisfied, are not readily or vividly recalled.

THIRDLY, after the power of language had been acquired, and the wishes of the community could be expressed, the common opinion how each member ought to act for the public good, would naturally become in a paramount degree the guide to action. But it should be borne in mind that however great weight we may attribute to public opinion, our regard for the approbation and disapprobation of our fellows

depends on sympathy, which, as we shall see, forms an essential part of the social instinct, and is indeed its foundation-stone.

LASTLY, habit in the individual would ultimately play a very important part in guiding the conduct of each member; for the social instinct, together with sympathy, is, like any other instinct, greatly strengthened by habit, and so consequently would be obedience to the wishes and judgment of the community.

Why Obey One Instinct Rather Than Another?

We have not, however, as yet considered the main point, on which, from our present point of view, the whole question of the moral sense turns. Why should a man feel that he ought to obey one instinctive desire rather than another? Why is he bitterly regretful, if he has yielded to a strong sense of self-preservation, and has not risked his life to save that of a fellow-creature? or why does he regret having stolen food from hunger?

It is evident in the first place, that with mankind the instinctive impulses have different degrees of strength; a savage will risk his own life to save that of a member of the same community, but will be wholly indifferent about a stranger: a young and timid mother urged by the maternal instinct will, without a moment's hesitation, run the greatest danger for her own infant, but not for a mere fellow-creature.

Nevertheless many a civilised man, or even boy, who never before risked his life for another, but full of courage and sympathy, has disregarded the instinct of self-preservation, and plunged at once into a torrent to save a drowning man, though a stranger.

The Golden Rule as an Evolutionary Endpoint

The moral sense perhaps affords the best and highest distinction between man and the lower animals; but I need say nothing on this head, as I have so lately endeavoured to shew that the social instincts,—the prime principle of man's moral constitution—with the aid of active intellectual powers and the effects of habit, naturally lead to the golden rule, "As ye would that men should do to you, do ye to them likewise;" and this lies at the foundation of morality.

After you read: Notice what kind of explanation Darwin is offering throughout. He describes a mechanism — pleasure in society, dissatisfaction when instinct is betrayed, the guiding force of public opinion, the strengthening effect of habit, and finally the way the more enduring social instincts come to override more transient ones like hunger or fear — that would produce something functioning like a conscience in any sufficiently social, sufficiently intelligent animal. Even when Darwin arrives at the golden rule itself, notice how he gets there: not by arguing that it is true, but by tracing the natural history of how a social, intelligent creature would come to feel its force. Nowhere in this chapter does Darwin argue that the resulting moral feelings track moral truth in some further, independent sense; he is explaining why the feelings would exist and take the shape they do. For your notebook, be precise: Darwin is making a claim about origin, not a claim about justification. Keep that distinction sharp as you move into the lesson's discussion of the naturalistic fallacy.